

How we Test



It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.



In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality/features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (▶).

The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

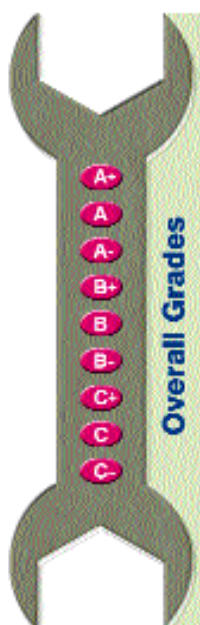
Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar

▶▶▶▶▶	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
▶▶▶▶▶	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
▶▶▶▶▶	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
▶▶▶▶▶	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
▶▶▶▶▶	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application

In Test this Month

After having tested and reviewed 588 hardware and software products during the course of this year in Digit, we bring to you the Zero1 Awards, the definitive award for excellence in performance. If you want to find out who's the best-of-class in the various product categories, turn to the Zero1 Awards feature this month. From 3D graphics cards to games, laser printers and scanners, we bring you the products that have excelled in technology, innovation and performance.

We also bring you a crop of some of the most bleeding-edge products in our Bazaar section. Reviewed here is the formidable Hercules 3D Prophet 9700 Pro graphics accelerator—to date, the fastest graphics card in the world for gaming. The product that could just make the sub-Rs 20,000 PC become a reality. Find out also how the new Mini-ITX form factor motherboard from VIA stacks up in our tests.

There are also a host of droolable peripherals such as the Logitech Cordless Freedom Optical keyboard and Microsoft's new wireless Intellimouse Explorer optical mouse.

On the software front, we review the newest iteration of Red Hat, version 8.0, and also a couple of great tools such as Norton AntiVirus 2003 for combating the threats posed by the increasing army of viruses, and Adobe LiveMotion 2.0, which will help you add pizzazz to your Web sites.